Substantive depth supplement — Paper II, Unit I, Topic 5

Focus: Gandhi–Irwin Pact, the Round Table Conferences, constitutional bargaining, mass mobilisation and Partition. This supplement adds explanation to an existing published draft; it does **not** certify the older chapter as academically approved. The original PDF is preserved.

1. Gandhi–Irwin Pact, 5 March 1931: why negotiations became possible

The Gandhi–Irwin Pact was a negotiated truce between Mahatma Gandhi, representing the Indian National Congress, and Viceroy Lord Irwin. Its immediate background was the Civil Disobedience Movement that followed the 1930 Salt March. Salt law violations, boycotts, demonstrations and arrests had shown that imperial authority could be challenged by disciplined mass action, but prolonged confrontation also imposed costs on participants and the colonial government. The First Round Table Conference in London (November 1930–January 1931) had proceeded without Congress participation, limiting its representative authority. Irwin needed a way to bring the largest nationalist organisation into constitutional discussion; Gandhi needed concessions sufficient to justify temporarily suspending civil disobedience.

Negotiation was neither a surrender nor a declaration of independence. It reflected an unstable balance: the government retained coercive institutions and final constitutional authority, while Congress possessed broad mobilising capacity but could not immediately compel full sovereignty. The agreement is therefore best understood as a political exchange rather than as an ideological reconciliation. A serious answer should identify the negotiators, the setting, the exchange of commitments and the unresolved conflicts.

2. What the pact provided—and what it did not

Congress agreed to suspend the Civil Disobedience Movement and participate in the next Round Table Conference. The government agreed, subject to qualifications, to release prisoners detained for nonviolent civil-disobedience activities, withdraw specified ordinances and prosecutions, return confiscated property not already sold where applicable, and permit peaceful picketing of liquor and foreign-cloth shops. Coastal communities were allowed limited salt manufacture for their own use. These concessions were significant because they recognised civil disobedience as a political force worthy of negotiation.

But the agreement did **not** grant dominion status, independence, a binding constitution or an unrestricted right to manufacture and sell salt. It did not provide general amnesty for those convicted of violent offences. It also did not stop the execution of Bhagat Singh, Rajguru and Sukhdev later in March 1931, a failure that generated severe criticism of Gandhi and the negotiating strategy. Claims that the pact “secured freedom” or “saved every political prisoner” are historically wrong. The agreement concerned immediate de-escalation and entry into talks, not the final settlement of colonial rule.

3. Why the agreement was controversial

Supporters saw a strategic recognition of Congress and a temporary opening for political prisoners and ordinary volunteers. They argued that disciplined movements require periods of negotiation and that participation in constitutional conferences could broaden the nationalist position. Critics regarded the concessions as inadequate after a mass campaign. Revolutionary nationalists objected to the exclusion of those convicted in violent cases and to the failure to obtain commutation of death sentences. Some peasant activists expected stronger commitments on rent, land revenue and police repression. The pact's language did not guarantee relief for every local grievance that participants had associated with civil disobedience.

These criticisms reveal a central tension in mass nationalism: a national negotiating organisation must frame demands that can be put into an agreement, but participants enter movements with heterogeneous aims. When a national leadership suspends agitation, it may appear to some supporters that their local sacrifices have been traded for limited institutional concessions. An excellent mains answer therefore weighs bargaining gains

against representational limits instead of offering a simple “success/failure” verdict.

4. Second Round Table Conference and the breakdown of the truce

Gandhi attended the Second Round Table Conference in London in 1931 as the Congress representative. The talks exposed deep disagreements over the structure of an Indian federation, safeguards for minorities and the nature of political representation. The British government emphasised constitutional complexity and communal questions, while Congress claimed to speak for a national demand for responsible self-government. Other representatives challenged Congress's claim to represent all communities. The conference failed to deliver a settlement acceptable to the principal parties.

After Gandhi's return, repression and confrontation resumed; Civil Disobedience was renewed in early 1932. The failure does not prove that participation was irrational. It shows the limits of bargaining when parties disagree over the unit of representation and when the colonial state controls the constitutional timetable. In analytical writing, distinguish the pact (March 1931), the Second Round Table Conference (September–December 1931), and the later 1932 constitutional controversies. They were linked but separate events.

5. The Poona Pact and the question of representation

The 1932 Communal Award proposed separate electorates for Depressed Classes. Dr B. R. Ambedkar defended distinct political safeguards against entrenched caste exclusion; Gandhi opposed separate electorates for Depressed Classes and began a fast in prison. The Poona Pact of September 1932 replaced the proposed separate electorates with reserved seats in joint electorates and additional arrangements. Its immediate compromise cannot be treated as proof that the underlying debate over independent Dalit political representation was resolved.

For TGPSC, the analytical point is that nationalism and social justice were not always expressed through identical institutional designs. Gandhi prioritised a conception of Hindu social unity, while Ambedkar insisted that representation must protect communities vulnerable to caste-majority domination. A strong answer describes the competing political principles without caricaturing either figure. The dispute also demonstrates why the Round Table period cannot be understood only as a negotiation between Congress and Britain.

6. From constitutional experiments to the 1942 rupture

The Government of India Act, 1935, introduced provincial autonomy but left decisive imperial controls in place and envisaged a federation that did not come into operation. Congress ministries formed in several provinces after the 1937 elections, creating experience of administration and sharpening disputes with other political parties. The Second World War changed the context dramatically: Britain involved India in war without obtaining consent from Indian elected representatives. Congress ministries resigned in 1939, and constitutional bargaining increasingly intersected with wartime security and economic hardship.

The Cripps Mission of 1942 offered a postwar constitutional framework but failed to secure agreement, partly because of unresolved issues concerning immediate responsible government, defence and future provincial options. The Quit India resolution of August 1942 demanded British withdrawal. Leaders were arrested and the movement developed varied regional forms, including strikes, underground communications and, in some places, sabotage. It is inaccurate to call the campaign uniformly nonviolent or uniformly centrally directed after arrests. The historical lesson is that repression can decentralise a movement and make its tactics less predictable.

7. Partition: constitutional decisions and human consequences

The 1946 Cabinet Mission Plan attempted to preserve an Indian Union through a complex federal arrangement, but disputes over grouping, sovereignty and political trust undermined implementation. The Direct Action Day violence and subsequent communal conflicts deepened insecurity. The Mountbatten Plan of June 1947 led toward Partition, and the Indian Independence Act of July 1947 created the legal framework for the two dominions in August. Dates should be tied to the correct instrument: the plan, the Act and the transfer of power

are not the same event.

Partition caused displacement, killings, abductions and long-term disruption, though exact aggregate figures vary by method and source. The political history must include the experience of refugees, women, minorities and communities whose lives were divided by borders. Explaining Partition solely as the decision of one leader is inadequate; the causes included constitutional deadlock, communal mobilisation, colonial policy and escalating violence. Yet a structural explanation must not erase the responsibility of organisations and individuals for particular acts.

8. Mains answer architecture and source caution

For “Critically evaluate the Gandhi–Irwin Pact,” write: **Background** (1930 Civil Disobedience and first conference), **Terms** (reciprocal suspension, prisoners, confiscation and picketing), **Benefits** (recognition, relief, constitutional access), **Limitations** (no independence, qualified amnesty, unresolved revolutionary prisoners), **Aftermath** (Second Round Table failure and renewed agitation), and **Conclusion** (a tactical truce, not a final settlement). For “Why did constitutional negotiations fail?”, separate disagreements over sovereignty, federal structure and representation. For “Was Partition inevitable?”, distinguish structural pressures from choices made in 1946–47.

The chapter's older segmented sources are consolidated in a new editable master for review. Any inherited “verified PYQ” heading should be read as a **placeholder unless it contains the original commission paper and question number**. A textbook-grade future revision must independently verify every factual claim, chronology and question provenance. No automatic academic approval follows from this supplement.

Focused quick revision

Event	Date	Distinguishing significance
First Round Table Conference	1930–31	Congress absent; representative deficit
Gandhi–Irwin Pact	5 March 1931	Suspension of Civil Disobedience for qualified concessions and conference participation
Second Round Table Conference	1931	Gandhi attended; constitutional settlement failed
Poona Pact	September 1932	Reserved seats in joint electorates after dispute over separate electorates
Government of India Act	1935	Provincial autonomy, proposed but unrealised federation
Cripps Mission	1942	Failed wartime constitutional offer
Quit India	August 1942	Mass demand for British withdrawal and subsequent repression
Cabinet Mission	1946	Attempt to devise constitutional union and grouping arrangement
Indian Independence Act	July 1947	Legislative basis for transfer of power and Partition